



SCHUYLKILL RIVER
NATIONAL & STATE HERITAGE AREA

Schuylkill River Land and Water Emergency Response Location System

Audit, Analysis and Recommendations

D r a f t v 2

Prepared for the
Schuylkill River National & State Heritage Area
Managed by the Schuylkill River Greenway Association

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This study of the Schuylkill River Valley National & State Heritage Area
was prepared for the Schuylkill River Greenway Association

Consultant Team

Cloud Gehshan Associates

Philadelphia, Pennsylvania

Project Management, Signage, Wayfinding and Emergency Response System

Standing Stone Consulting, Inc.

Huntingdon, Pennsylvania

*Analysis and Recommendations for Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design
and Response Enhanced Design*



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SCHUYLKILL RIVER NATIONAL & STATE HERITAGE AREA

A Region Revitalized and Restored

Few places in America can claim the Schuylkill River Heritage Area's importance in history.

A variety of peoples—from the Lenni Lenapi to the first European settlers to the many other ethnic groups who migrated to the Schuylkill region over time—have called the River Valley home. Its abundant natural resources and productive soils made it an early industrial center and breadbasket for the colonies. During the American Revolution, the perseverance and sacrifice of George Washington's army at Valley Forge played a key role in the birth of a new nation. The 19th century witnessed the emergence of the Schuylkill Valley as one of the world's leading manufacturing regions, fueled in large part by anthracite coal mined from Schuylkill County. The Schuylkill River and canal system were one of the major arteries of the Industrial Revolution, transporting coal, manufactured goods, and crops to the port of Philadelphia. Industrial and mining activities impacted the Schuylkill River Valley's water resources, leading to a new chapter in its history in the 20th century—one of environmental reclamation and water quality restoration on a massive scale, accompanied by the emergence of outdoor recreation as a major activity.

Today the Schuylkill River Heritage Area is a diverse and dynamic region. The Heritage Area's five counties—Berks, Chester, Montgomery, Philadelphia, and Schuylkill—are inhabited by some 3.2 million people. The Area boasts abundant cultural, natural, and recreational resources; landmark sites of national significance; and historic communities and landscapes with uncounted stories to tell of the region's heritage. Nevertheless, while much of the region's past survives in the present, some significant challenges exist if the past is to be carried forward into the future.

As established by Congress, the mission of the heritage area is:

To conserve, interpret and develop the historical, cultural, natural and recreational resources related to the industrial and cultural heritage of the Schuylkill River Valley.

The Schuylkill River National Heritage Area's Vision Statement is:

We envision a Schuylkill River region fully revitalized and restored: A region whose citizens understand, value and are fully committed to preserving and sustaining their cultural heritage and natural environment for future generations.

The Schuylkill River Greenway Association (SRGA) is the designated management organization for the heritage area.

Our **mission** is to inform, coordinate, lead and assist communities, organizations and citizens in achieving the stated Vision.



Introduction

In December 2003, The Schuylkill River Greenway Association with the help of Cloud Gehshan Associates and Standing Stone Consulting Inc., conducted an assessment of sample sections of river and land trails along the Schuylkill River Valley National Heritage Area for the purpose of establishing an emergency management sign system. The study of the Schuylkill River Valley areas consisted of site observations, surveys and interviews with area stakeholders and emergency service providers within five counties – Schuylkill, Berks, Montgomery, Chester and Philadelphia. The first task was to develop goals and criteria for developing a sign system.

The first goal for this project is to create an information system of the Schuylkill River Valley Heritage Area that helps visitors safely navigate the water and land trails. The system should work with existing park and trail sign systems and complement the natural surroundings. The system should be clear, simple and durable, as well as easily maintained and updated.

A second goal is to develop a location marker system for land and water based travelers to effectively communicate their location to emergency medical service personnel. The location marker system should coordinate road access, foot trail access and river access points for emergency response. The signs should also warn of restrictions, for example, if fire trucks or emergency vehicles were incapable of traversing a certain area of foot trail.

A third goal is to increase river water trail users ease of identifying their location by reinforcing location of man-made and geographical features. Marking the river water trail should rely more on adding place/geographic names to existing structures than introducing signs and clutter in the natural environment.

A fourth goal is to assess the aesthetics, infrastructure and various amenities of the trail and provide recommendations for creating a safer user experience.

A fifth goal is to create awareness and promote the identity of the Schuylkill River Valley National and State Heritage Area. Defining and creating that image is a major design goal. Clearly creating a positive and memorable image will benefit the SRVN&SHA and the local communities. Access to safe and pleasant parks and trail systems improve the experience for visitors and residents alike.

Upon completing the audit and analysis several issues were identified that should be addressed immediately. The five top issues are:

- A lack of appropriate warning signs
- A lack of supported coordination of location indicators to be used between users of the trails, 911 operators and emergency response personnel
- A lack of sign message continuity
- Inadequate maintenance policies and procedures for the signs
- A lack of a proactive hazard surveillance system, where users are directed how and where to report hazards and developing hazards

This master wayfinding and emergency response plan addresses some of these issues by developing a location indicator system, providing recommendations and methods that will increase a safer user experience, and identifying sign types that will carry the messages needed to create a comprehensive information system. The last chapter outlines a plan for implementation and maintenance and creates a preliminary budget for the system's realization.



SCHUYLKILL RIVER NATIONAL & STATE HERITAGE AREA

Introduction, continued

But these tools alone will not make a successful sign system or create a safe environment. They need to be developed as part of a larger plan, which takes time and commitment from all stakeholders. To implement a successful visitor information system the following additional tasks will need to be completed:

- Conduct an audit of existing signage and develop a database for managing content, condition and location
- Develop a sign design guideline manual
- Implement the location indicator system
- Develop a marketing plan to help raise awareness of the trails and the emergency response system
- Develop a plan for the phased implementation of directional, orientation and regulatory signs
- Implementation of a maintenance plan and access to temporary signs

In order to create increased awareness, ownership and pride in the Schuylkill River and Water Trails, a lot more needs to be done than just implementing a sign system. Community events, community involvement, and well-maintained trails and parks will attract users and effectively increase safety and security.

